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The Age of Lions

The Gangetic plain was the birthplace of the next cycle of urbanization. From 1300 to 400 BC, the area was made up of a network of small kingdoms and republics. Many of them were centred around towns. We come across place-names that are still in use, and remarkable socio-cultural continuities. Modern Indian children are still brought up on legends and bedtime stories that originate from this era. For the first time, we see an awareness of the whole subcontinent as a geographical and civilizational unit. It is also a time that we witness the growing cultural importance of the Asiatic lion—an animal that would come to occupy a central role in Indian symbolism. One of the most important cultural contributions of the period was the composition of the two great epics Ramayana and Mahabharata. They tell us a lot about how the geographical conception of India evolved in the Iron Age.

THE GEOGRAPHY OF THE EPICS

The great epics Ramayana and Mahabharata have long been central to Indian culture. From religious philosophy to art and common idiom, they remain a part of everyday life. Their depiction as a television serial in the late eighties brought the country to a virtual standstill whenever an episode was aired. A dispute over the birthplace of Rama, the central character of the Ramayana, fundamentally changed Indian politics in the early nineties.